

Composition

When planning a painting, you have to decide what you want to focus on in your picture and what you want to leave out. Simplicity is the key to success when you start painting, and editing will strengthen

your composition. You will also need to choose where you position the different elements of your painting. In a successful composition, they will be placed so that they lead the viewer into the painting.

VIEWFINDER

Use a viewfinder as a framing device that you can move in front of your subject to help you visualize how it will look in a variety of compositions. You can make a simple viewfinder by holding two L-shaped pieces of tagboard to make a rectangle, as shown on the right. You can change the shape and size of the rectangle by moving the pieces of board closer to each other or further apart.

Slide the corners of the board in and out to frame and crop the picture.



FORMAT

Deciding what format—shape of paper—to use is an important part of planning a composition. The three paintings below show how the choice of format can direct attention to different focal

points. The formats used for this study are: portrait (a vertical rectangle, higher than it is wide), landscape (a horizontal rectangle, wider than it is high), and square.



Landscape format The horizontal nature of this picture draws attention to the colorful shed doors and angles of the trees. The building on the left directs the eye to the center of the composition.

Portrait format The large amount of space given to the foreground in this design leads the eye along the road and into the picture.



Square format Here the roofs and doorways have been included. The trees on the left act as a counterpoint to this detail on the right and help to create a balanced composition.